

MEET 'EM AT THE FEST
The Anirudh Varma Collective performs at a 2024 concert; below, Manipuri band Imphal Talkies & The Howlers

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Google T.M. Krishna's name and chances are you will come upon terms such as 'rebel', 'rule-breaker' or 'controversy's child' to describe him. However, the Carnatic musician, author and activist has no desire to be boxed into narrow definitions. "Throwing these tags and phrases are just laziness and an inability to engage. I don't see a necessity to respond to any of that and/or reject or accept them," he says.

Perhaps it is this refusal to not conform to rigid definitions that compelled him to say yes to becoming the curator of the second edition of the KNMA Festival presented by the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art. With the focus this time on 'Voices of Diversity'—although Krishna prefers the term 'non-exclusivity'—here was an opportunity to showcase and share life experiences, realities, ideas in abstract ways, through song, through meter and poetry and through movement.

So, while there is a performance by India's all-female hip-hop collective Wild Wild Women, there's also Manipuri folk rock band Imphal Talkies & The Howlers. There's also Bollywood-inspired B Side Project by Anirudh Varma Collective, a Carnatic baithak by Jayanthi Kumaresh and Kashmiri rock by Parvez, among others. "What ties it together is that all these people with different languages, tones and perspectives are engaging in the present.... I'm glad that you cannot define this festival as a classical festival or a rock festival or a hip-hop festival," he elaborates.

Reflecting on his journey, Krishna says, "I came from, and still am, in great privilege. In my early 20s, all I wanted to do was become famous, sing at a lot of concerts, make money and travel the world. The word I'd use for myself at that point is avaricious. I don't think I was really awakened to the larger world within the way I see my music." He says it was a long process of pause, and a "great amount of discomfort and uncertainty", that moved him into the trajectory "that has gotten me where I am today."



Krishna has collaborated with **Perumal Murugan, and brought the poetry** of Sri Narayana Guru into the Carnatic fold

Krishna does not have a clear answer to how he reached this point, but he remembers his home being an emotionally and intellectually active place, where there were no limitations to what he could ask or discuss. The greatest gift his school gave him, he recalls, is to teach him how to ask questions. "These learnings stayed with me. At some point, they started challenging the individual that I was," he says. Music, he believes, also led him to questioning the norms around who can have access to art. With each performance, the questions gnawed at him—Why was he singing this